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A Mid-Term Paper on

Social Policy: Concept, Goals and Influencing Factors

Course Title – Social Policy and Program Planning

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❖ Introduction

‘Social policy’ is just one specific aspect of the larger field of policy formulation. A state may have many types of policies. For example, foreign policy, finance and trade policy, military or defense policy, revenue policy, education policy, youth policy, population policy, labor policy and many other policies, these are working in different ways in different fields. Among these policies, those which are related to social problems and the normal life of the mass people are considered to be subject to specific boundaries of social policy.

In particular, a policy will be considered a social policy if it is directly and indirectly related to social problems. For example, income tax is considered a social policy that affects poverty and employment, but it is not a social policy when the same proposition is used to control the price of goods for businesses. Because in the first case it is related to the social problem but in the last case it is related to the person. So in the first case it is considered as social policy but in the second case it will not be considered as social policy. The domain of social policy is vast. In fact, it largely serves to define a society. It includes most of what a community collectively does to protect its weakest members, but it also has to meet the social needs of all.

❖ Concept of Social Policy

Broadly speaking, the term ‘policy’ refers to the general guidelines or principles, which give direction to a particular course of action by the government or by an organisation. It also refers to, in a very specific sense, an intended or executed course of action. Social policy is concerned with the ways societies across the world meet human needs for security, education, work, health and wellbeing. Social policy addresses how states and societies respond to global challenges of social, demographic and economic change, and of poverty, migration and globalisation.

❖ Definitions of Social Policy

An attempt to define social policy is beset with many practical difficulties. Is there one social policy with capital S and P or are there multiple social policies with small s and small p? This question is relevant because we have social policies compartmentalized into a policy for scheduled

castes, a policy for backward classes, a policy for weaker sections, a policy for women, a policy for children and so on. Does an addition of these policies make up a “whole” social policy? We have Directive Principles of State Policy, the Fundamental Rights and the preamble to the constitution. Do these make up a social policy? In the light of the above dilemmas, in the following section, we attempt to define social policy:

Definitions of Social Policy According to David Gill: Social policies are principles/ course of action designed to influence:

- i) the overall quality of life in a society;
- ii) the circumstances of living of individuals and groups in that society; and
- iii) the nature of intra- societal relationships among individuals, groups and society as a whole.

According to Social work Dictionary “Social policy is the activities and principles of a society that guide the way it intervenes in and regulates relationships between individuals, groups, communities and social institutions.” (Barker, 1987)

According to Prof. Titmuss, “social policy represents a summation of acts of government, deliberately designed to improve the welfare of people.” (Titmuss, 1950)

While summarizing the whole discussion, it can be said that social policy is a deliberate action on the part of individuals, collectivities and governments, undertaken to organise services, opportunities and social action so as to affect the life-styles of people and initiate a process to prevent, postpone, initiate and manage change.

❖ **Characteristics of Social Policy**

- 1) Many writers on social policy including such well known names like Titmuss, Donnison and Boulding 208 Social Work Intervention with Individuals and Groups have stressed that the distinguishing trait of social policy is its distributional or redistributive character.
- 2) The second characteristic of social policy is its concern with weaker and vulnerable sections of society such as poor, women, children, disabled, backward classes so as to bring them at par with

the rest of society. Thus social policies visualize of an egalitarian society where inequalities are reduced to minimum level.

3) Another characteristic of social policy is that social policies do not exist in isolation. These are determined to a large extent by the socio-political scenario of a nation, its economic viability and last but not the least, by socio-cultural ethos of people of the nation. Now after Liberalisation, Globalisation and Privatization, policies have become global and changes in one corner of the world definitely leave impact over rest of the world.

❖ Goals of Social Policy

The suffix 'social policy' refers to a clear field in policy making, namely- society. It is clear from the suffix that social policy is formulated in an attempt to achieve various goals related to society. Social policy is formulated with the aim of conducting social welfare activities smoothly. The concept of social welfare is as broad as the concept of social policy. The task of clearly identifying the purpose of this social policy is not at all easy. Different scholars have tried to present the purpose of social policy in different ways. However, it is generally said that 'social policy' is a policy formulated in an effort to create a social environment for overcoming undesirable social conditions (e.g. social chaos, social problems, etc.), meet the needs and wants of the people and address their problems. Professor Titmass gives an indication of its purpose in his definition of social policy. He said- Activities which serve a common purpose related to the welfare needs of a society. In other words, he has highlighted the fulfillment of the social welfare needs of a society as an objective. He also sets out three clear objectives of social policy in his texts-

- A. Policy is directed to provide welfare for citizens.
- B. Policy includes economic as well as non-economic objectives for example: minimum wages, minimum standard of income maintenance and so on
- C. Social policy involve some measures of progressive re-distribution in command over resources from rich to poor.

In other words, the main objective of social policy is to create a field for poverty alleviation and to make arrangements for the people to participate in those programs. The objectives of the policy are implemented on the basis of the plan adopted under the specific direction of the policy.

1. Poverty alleviation

There is no specific definition of poverty. Poverty is basically defined differently based on different times. Poverty is determined by the quality of life of different societies. Poverty generally refers to the relatively poor or the relatively disadvantaged. One of the objectives of the social policy is to develop the underprivileged people, to create opportunities for the underprivileged to improve their living standards through specific plans and to help them overcome the situation.

2. Dealing with undesirable and social situations as well as social problems

The problem is a universal one. In every society there are some social problems in the social context of that society. The nature of the problem may vary from one society to another. But the problem is everywhere. Effective tackling of social problems is essential for its continuity and development while maintaining social stability. One of the objectives of social policy is therefore to ensure proper social environment by addressing social problems.

3. Bringing planned social change

One of the objectives of social policy is to ensure social change by managing the pace of social change in a positive way. Social policy ensures the desired social change by correcting and changing the negative aspects of the attitude, customs and principles of social organization and said that social policy is considered as a positive element of change. In a patriarchal society, most of the problems in the family and social context, such as discriminatory attitudes towards women, including education and employment, are through social policy and planning based on that.

4. Ensuring equality of resources and opportunities

Social policy strives to ensure equal participation of all citizens in resources and opportunities. One of the objectives of social policy is to ensure equal rights for all by eliminating social discrimination and inequality. The direction of equitable distribution of social resources while maintaining the fundamental rights of everyone in the society is found through social policy.

5. Ensuring social security

Problems and misfortunes are an essential part of human life. Various catastrophes have made human life miserable which is not always possible for every person to be overcome by his family but the need for outside help and cooperation becomes essential. In these situations, the special security measures taken by the society or the state to help the person to overcome the opposite situation is known as social security. Social security is ensured through social policy.

6. Ensuring maximum welfare of the society

The basic purpose of social policy is to ensure the highest social welfare. Social welfare has to do with social policy. It is formulated and implemented for the welfare of the society. Social principles are closely related to welfare. Scholars have highlighted social welfare as the purpose of social policy. Generally, social insurance, social assistance, health care, education, housing, etc. are provided through social policy.

7. Preservation of the helpless, oppressed and downtrodden rights of the society

The most important part of social policy is the socially disadvantaged, disadvantaged people. Most social policies are formulated to protect the interests of the de facto neglected class. In order to protect the weak from the oppression of the strong, social policy is formulated for the purpose of establishing their just rights by preventing oppression and torture. Through the redistribution of social resources, the state facilities are neglected, and the social policy provides guidelines for specific activities to ensure the participation of the backward people in the social environment by ensuring their full dignity.

8. Increasing the effectiveness of social institutions

Due to the lack of proper coordination of government activities conducted through various social organizations, a lot of resources of the country are wasted every year. Through sound policies, it is possible to ensure the effectiveness of the activities of such organizations on the one hand, and on the other hand, through the coordinated coordination of the programs of these organizations. The social policy gives clear direction to the smooth coordination of the activities of these government institutions in the economically developed countries.

9. Creating field for development planning

In addition to building an orderly social structure, social policy prepares the ground for sustainable social development planning. Social policy facilitates the implementation of development plans by identifying and addressing the problems created in the implementation of development plans and programs. One of the features of social policy is that it helps social planners to determine the easiest and most effective way to achieve the goal.

10. Build an orderly social structure

An orderly social structure is essential for social development. Social policy builds an orderly social structure by tackling social problems, equitable distribution of wealth, adopting the principle of social equality and establishing social justice. Where basic human rights are guaranteed and full freedom is guaranteed the best social welfare.

11. Ensuring social justice

Social justice is concerned with ensuring the just rights of the individual while maintaining the fundamental rights of every member of society. For example, ensuring the receipt of a worker, ensuring the participation of all, especially the weaker sections of our society. One of the objectives of social policy is to ensure social justice for the weaker sections and to give them full dignity.

In other words, the protection of the interests of a particular class in the community is a cause of social concern and social policy is related to it. However, it not only protects the interests of special classes but also protects the interests of different sections of the society according to their needs.

❖ Influencing Factors in Social Policy

Social policy is adopted by the government for the welfare of the people based on their perceived needs. These principles related to the society are formulated in the context of the customs and values of the society. The first values involve various socio-economic, religious, cultural and political elements. It can be seen that these factors directly and indirectly influence the formulation

of social policy. More precisely the elements determine which social policy of a society is appropriate. The factors influencing policy making are considered as social policy makers. Influencing Factors in Social Policy are mentioned below-

1. Economic Factor

It is one of the most important factors influencing the formulation of social policy in a state or society. The economic structure of the country determines in some cases how much public welfare policy will be adopted. Economically strong countries can conduct comprehensive social insurance programs and social services programs to improve their economic, educational and trade order. But in underdeveloped states where economic fragility, GDP growth rates are low, it is impossible to run social insurance and social services programs. As a result, the nature of social policies in these countries is not like that of rich countries. It is not a matter of formulating policies but its effective implementation. In this case, if there is insufficiency of resources required for implementation, it is unnecessary to adopt the policy.

2. Political Factor

political factor is as important as the economic factor. It plays a very important role in determining the policy of a country. In other words, the type and nature of a country's policy is determined by the political element of the country concerned. The relationship between politicians and administrators plays a very important role in government activities and policy making. Again, just as there is a difference in political equality from one state to another, there is also a difference in government policy. Because modern democracies have adopted welfare state policies, democracies have important social policies to ensure the social security of the people in the society. Again, in monarchical states, the welfare of the people is not very important. Among the political elements that play an important role in determining social policy are-

a. Political Philosophy

Social policy depends a lot on what kind of political philosophy the government is run by. The attitude of the government and the ruling party determines the political ideology and the nature of the social policy of a country.

b. Peaceful politics

A stable political environment does not make it possible to implement various long-term programs. Moreover, it does not accept the accepted program. Above all, in an unstable political environment, the government cannot focus too much on formulating and implementing social policies.

c. Political motives

Like political philosophy, the political motives of different state systems are different. One of the objectives of the welfare state is to ensure the highest welfare of the people. In a capitalist society, the responsibility of the government is of the police type.

3. Cultural Factors

Each country develops their culture based on long-term livelihoods which have a very important impact on their way of life. This culture of any society or country is formed on the basis of their common and religious beliefs, social customs, values and ideals. Culture has a very close relationship with life. Among the cultural elements, the aspects that need to be taken into account in formulating social policy are-

A. Family System

As the smallest basic unit of the state, the family and the family system are very important elements of every society. The culture, values and values of a particular society are formed on the basis of the nature of the family. The type of family arrangement is therefore important in determining social policy.

B. Religion

Religious consciousness and faith are considered as forces. It is not possible to implement any policy that hurts religious sentiments. The religious aspect is very important for him in formulating social policy.

D. Norms and values

Social norms contrary to the ideals and values that the greater masses of a society believe in and follow will be rejected by them, so it will not be possible to implement them. Social policy has to be formulated in keeping with the social norms, principles and norms.

D. Social customs and festivals

Social customs and religious festivals are important elements of Sanskrit. These form a close relationship with the way of life of the people in the society. In formulating social policy, these issues have to be taken into consideration and policies have to be formulated in harmony with them.

4. National Defence

In any country, the defense system of the country concerned has an important influence in formulating social policy. What matters is the political situation in the country, whether the defense system is strong, and whether there is a possibility of an attack by a neighboring state. The national defense system influences the formulation of social policy in two ways. First, as a large portion of the total national income is spent on the defense sector, it is not possible to adopt social programs without the necessary financial support for the adoption and implementation of social policies. Second, the government has to pay too much attention to the defense sector, so it remains socially neglected.

5. International Aid

One of the characteristics of developing countries in the third world is that they are unable to formulate budgets and implement social policies with their own resources due to economic constraints. Donors cover a number of conditions related to their interests that are essential to borrowing, which the recipient countries must comply with. Among these, countries determine social policy, how much to spend in which sectors or in which areas priority will be given. In other words, in their interest, they provide foreign aid, which has a significant impact on the policy of the recipient countries.

6. International Consultant

Especially when there is a need to formulate social policy in new problems or new social fields, if there is a shortage of local experts or in developed countries in terms of information technology, experts are often brought in from outside to develop appropriate technology infrastructure under whose direction social policy is formulated. Needless to say, these factors influence policy-making.

7. Interest of the Recipients

The interests of those for whom social policy will be adopted are extremely important. If the interests of those for whom the policy is to be formulated are not properly considered, the policy will not be implemented. In this case, the needs and aspirations of the recipients should be reflected in the social policy.

❖ Conclusion

Social policy is increasingly a reality in the developing world. It typically comprises a rather complex web of legislation, institutions and provision that seeks to meet the kind of individual and social needs that are not adequately met by markets, be it for reasons of effectiveness or ideology. It is related to the governmental approach of development of social services towards formation of a welfare state.

